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💫 Recording Quality Expectations

Core Recording Standards

A strong recording shows a complete, realistic professional workflow. It should demonstrate how you think, make decisions, use your tools, and produce a usable result.

> ⏱️**Task Length:** Plan each recording, including the short intro and epilogue, to be at least 15 minutes and no more than 50:59 minutes (15:00-50:59).

What a Strong Recording Demonstrates

Quality	What It Means
Natural	Work and narrate as you normally would when demonstrating a professional process.
Complete	Show the full workflow through completion and saving of the final deliverables.
Correct	Use your @mercor.expert account or a new anonymised account, apps that comply with the current banned-app and limited-use rules, the required resolution, and proper recording setup. Unrestricted apps need no prior approval.
Mostly Mouse-Driven	Use visible application controls whenever practical. Avoid long typing-only sections and excessive keyboard shortcuts.
Professional	Apply meaningful expertise, methods, standards, calculations, or decision-making.
Deliberate	Work at a natural pace and allow actions to finish before continuing. Do not rush through the task.
Appropriate	Do not display sexually explicit, graphically violent, hateful, discriminatory, or otherwise prohibited content.

In This Section

1. **Domain Expertise**

Demonstrate domain expertise and avoid repeatedly submitting the same workflow.

1. **Narration**

Narrate What and Where, and explain Why for important or non-obvious decisions, with clear, continuous, synchronized audio.

1. **Apps and Desktop**

Use genuine task apps, avoid restricted software, and maintain a clean recording environment.

1. **On-Screen Presentation**

Manage windows clearly, use the cursor as a teaching pointer, and follow the typing limits.

1. **PII, Licensed Content, and AI Use**

Protect private information, use permitted content, and avoid prohibited AI interactions.

Complete and Meaningful Final Output

Create at least one final deliverable during the recording. It should be accurate, complete, clean, readable, and usable by a client, stakeholder, or colleague. Before stopping the recording, review the finished work and confirm that it was saved and rendered correctly.

Follow the Organize Output instructions for file naming conventions.

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RECORDING QUALITY EXPECTATIONS

🧠 Domain Expertise

Professional Expertise and Task Variety

A strong recording shows how a professional thinks, makes decisions, and verifies their work. Across tasks, it should also demonstrate meaningful variety rather than repeating the same workflow with a different topic.

Demonstrate Professional Expertise

Apply methods and skills you already understand. Explain what you are analyzing, changing, or deciding, why those choices matter, and how you will verify the results.

Demonstrate Expertise	Does Not Prove Expertise
Applying domain standards, calculations, or decision criteria	Using a professional title or technical vocabulary
Explaining the reasoning behind important choices	Only opening a complex application
Using app features and methods appropriate to your task	Completing only generic actions that do not use domain knowledge
Checking the final result against clear requirements	Adding unnecessary apps, clicks, or steps

The task should show skills and judgment you already have, with app use appropriate to the work.

You can show professional expertise through a technically deep workflow or, when the assigned app is simple by nature, through clear professional reasoning about choices, standards, risks and checks. Unless an announced supporting-app exception applies, the assigned app should do most of the work.

Mistakes and Corrections

Small slips are normal. If you mistype, misclick or open the wrong menu now and then, notice it, say what you are fixing, fix it, check the fix and carry on. Restart only if:

1. searching, guessing, undoing or redoing starts to take over the recording, or
2. an error changes the final result and you cannot fix it on screen.

Frequent errors that break the flow of the task will be sent back. Do not learn the software by trial and error while recording: know how you will do each step before you start. Do not re-record just for an occasional corrected typo; submit and use the review feedback."

One small mistake does not automatically invalidate a recording. Occasional small slips are acceptable when you identify the mistake, explain the correction, fix it and check the result. Restart if repeated searching, guessing, undoing or redoing dominates the recording, or a material error cannot be corrected on screen.

Create Meaningful Task Variety

You may not submit tasks **that substantially repeat the same workflow**. You may reuse the same app, but the work performed should change meaningfully.

You can create variety by changing:

- The professional objective
- The type or structure of the inputs
- The decisions, constraints, or evaluation criteria
- The methods, calculations, or specialist features used
- How information moves between apps
- The final deliverable and how it is verified

Task variety is checked when you propose your idea on the Mercor Studio. Ideas that substantially repeat existing work will not be approved.

Note:

- Changing only the title, client, topic, location, colors, browser, dataset, or file format is insufficient.
- Replacing an app with another app that performs the same function is also too similar.

Changing only the topic, wording, company name, colors, or source material does not create a meaningfully different workflow

---

A small mistake is handled deliberately

Q: Which recording meets the standard?

❝ **meets the standard.** Professional methods are applied, a meaningful different workflow is demonstrated, and one small mistake is handled deliberately. ❞

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🎙️ Narration Requirements

Narration Quality

TaskRecorder captures microphone audio, and narration is required throughout the task. Speak like a professional teaching a colleague who cannot see your screen.

Prepare Your Audio

Before recording:

1. Check your microphone in TaskRecorder in the top-right menu bar.
2. Say a short test sentence and confirm that the volume bar beside the preview rises into the **green**.
3. Keep the selected microphone connected for the entire recording.

Do not switch, disconnect, or reconnect input or output devices while recording. If a previous recording lost audio, make a short control recording with the built-in microphone before attempting another full task.

When available, use headphones with a dedicated microphone for clearer audio.

Note: For **audio or video tasks** that will feature audio playback, TaskRecorder does not capture internal system audio stream. Audio will only be captured by TaskRecorder if played aloud and picked up by your microphone.

Narrate the Complete Workflow

Narrate your thought process and meaningful actions, including:

- What you are analyzing, changing or deciding
- Mouse movements, clicks, and scrolling
- Why you selected a method, setting, or value
- What happened after the action
- How you verified the result
- **NEW** - Epilogue narration
  - **All task ideas originally approved at or after Oct 19, 2026 6PM PT must include an epilogue narration. Tasks whose ideas were** originally approved before this time do not need to include an epilogue narration. Later revision or reapproval does not remove this exemption. In Full Workflow, tick the epilogue checkbox for a completed required epilogue or an exempt pre-cutoff idea. The checkbox confirms either condition; do not tick it if neither is true. If an AutoQC finding is wrong, dispute it with a written reason; see Studio Workflow for the submission steps**.**
  - After the task is finished and before you close the task recorder, provide a brief summary of your work, including your assessment of whether the task was completed, any relevant reflections, or any other important highlights to mention. Below are the possible questions to cover:

- **Completion and outcome:** How did you verify the successful completion of the task? Were there any limitations?
- **Approach and key decision:** What was your overall approach? Why did you choose this approach?
- **Challenges and problem solving:** What was the most difficult, ambiguous, or unexpected part? Did you encounter any errors or need to change your approach? How did you resolve the issue?
- **Quality assessment:** How would you evaluate the quality of your final result? Are there any weaknesses or potential issues with the result?
- **Reflection and improvement**: If you were to do the task again, what would you do differently? If you had additional time, what would you improve or verify?
- **Insight:** What is one important principle, consideration, or common mistake that someone less experienced might overlook when performing this type of task?

- **T**arget a 3-4 minute epilogue narration, with a maximum of 4:00. Three minutes is not a minimum; cover the required reflections. Epilogues longer than 4:00 may be sent back.
- **Mouse is permitted to remain idle during the epilogue narration**

Speaking frequently is not enough. A listener should be able to identify the exact app and control, understand the purpose of the action, follow the workflow in the correct order, and hear the confirmed result without seeing the screen.

DO NOT simply read or recite the written Task Description (Goal).

Use What and Where (Why When It Matters)

For each meaningful step, say what you are doing, identify the control and where it is on screen, and explain the purpose or result when it is not obvious. Keep your cursor on the item you are naming. Speak naturally; while an occasional ‘this’ or ‘here’ is fine when the reference is clear, do not make viewers guess. Every detail should be talked through with extreme detail.

Common Mistakes: Narrate the action and exact location of meaningful steps, and the purpose when it is not obvious, with your cursor on the item you name."

Element	Explain
What	The action you are taking
Where	The exact app, control, file, value, or interface location
Why	The purpose or what happens after the action, when it is not obvious
Cursor	Point to or briefly hover over the item you name; tracing text while reading can help

> Example: ❝ I’ll click the Title 2 at the top to open the Headings Dropdown Menu, then select Subtitles to change the text to the subtitle headings format. ❞

Narration is **REQUIRED** for each meaningful step.

Use it naturally to teach the workflow, not to list robotic actions.

Narration Examples

1. Finance: calculate the purchase-order total

Source video at 11:45

- “Now I need to figure out what the total order value is.” [What] [Why]
- “I can do that by adding this £12,474 amount to the £62,370.” [What] [Why]
- “I'm going to left-click on the plus sign in Calculator, then enter six, two, three, seven, zero.” [What] [Where]

- "I'll click equals at the bottom-right of the Calculator." [What] [Where]
- "The final value is £74,844, exactly what it should be per the contract." [What] [Why]

2. Typography: narrow the anatomy list to eight terms

Source video at 00:48

- "I'm only going to show the eight I think are most important in this presentation." [What] [Why]
- "I'll drag from just after Shoulder up to just below Counter." [What] [Where]
- "On the right-hand side, I'll click the strikethrough text option." [What] [Where]
- "I'll select Leading and click strikethrough, then select from Stroke up to Stem and do the same." [What] [Where]
- "That should leave me with eight." [What]

3. Audio and music: set the string-track level

Source video at 06:20

- "We've properly loaded our additional string track." [What]
- "Just to the lower right of Authentic Strings is its volume slider." [Where]
- "These string patches tend to be very loud, so I'll click the volume slider." [What] [Why]
- "I'll move it left to about minus 10 dB, which is a good place to start." [What] [Why]

4. VFX: give the printed ink a slight height

Source video at 30:55

- "I'll navigate down to Height." [What] [Where]
- "The red ink on a cardboard box forms a slightly raised layer." [Why]
- "I'll go to the black-and-white gradient bar under Height and click the zero in its text box." [What] [Where]
- "I'll type 0.01 for an ever-so-slight height difference and press Enter." [What] [Why]

5. Software: apply the exported app icon

Source video at 24:11

- "I'll click General on the right side of the Project Navigator." [What] [Where]
- "I'll drag the scrollbar down until I see App Icons and Launch Screen." [What] [Where]
- "In that section, I'll click the App Icon field, type AppIcon without a space, and press Enter." [What] [Where]
- "This applies the icon we exported to the app." [What] [Why]

Name the Exact Target

Avoid vague references such as "this", "that", or "here". Identify each item clearly before or while interacting with it.

Avoid	Use Instead
I'll click this button	I'll select the blue Export button in the top-right corner
I'm changing that value	I'm changing the font size, which is currently set to 12
I'll click the right-side button	I'll select Plotly's camera icon, Download as PNG
I'll place that up there	I'll click, hold, and drag the title to the upper center of the Preview
It's saved	Article.pdf is now saved in the Desktop folder

For an unlabeled icon, name its app or panel, function, or visible symbol. Identify visual assets by their subject or filename, not only by position or color.

Coordinate Your Voice and Cursor

Your narration, cursor, and on-screen action should work together.

- Name the target before or while moving toward it.
- Rest the cursor briefly over the named control before acting.
- When searching, scan the relevant menu or toolbar naturally and explain what you expect to find.
- If an action fails, explain what happened, make one deliberate correction, and confirm the corrected result.
- Announce every keyboard shortcut before or while using it.

Follow the Audio Standards

Will be approved if:	Will be rejected if:
Describes What / Where during the action, and Why for important or non-obvious decisions. Follows the video; the cursor points, hovers, and guides attention. The voiceover is clear, coherent, understandable, and free of sustained or distracting background noise. Announces every keyboard shortcut before or as it is used. 100% in English, including reading	Misses actions, mismatches the video, or recites the written Task Description (Goal) instead of narrating the work. Narration is too vague to identify What, Where, or the result. An audio pause exceeds 60 seconds. Gaps of 46-60 seconds receive nonblocking feedback; aim for gaps of 45 seconds or less. Background noise obscures over 40% of the narration. Noise obscuring 30-40% receives nonblocking feedback; aim for clear audio. Uses keyboard shortcuts without verbal explanation. Audio includes private or non-public PII or profanity.

Review the Audio

Before submitting, review the recording to confirm that:

- Narration is audible near the beginning, middle, and end.
- The narration matches the actions shown.
- Aim for audio gaps of 45 seconds or less. Gaps of 46-60 seconds are nonblocking; a gap over 60 seconds fails.
- Actions, decisions, and results are explained clearly.
- Aim for clear narration without sustained background noise. Noise obscuring 30-40% of narration is nonblocking; over 40% fails. No private information or profanity.
- Every keyboard shortcut is announced.

Pause and Decide

Q: Which recording meets the standard?

❝ **meets the standard.** The narration identifies the app and location, explains the purpose, confirms the result, and announces the keyboard shortcut. ❞

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🛠️ Apps and Desktop

Apps and Desktop

A strong recording uses tools that genuinely contribute to the work, a fresh browser, and a clean desktop that varies naturally across tasks.

Choose Apps that Contribute

Choose the app or apps that suit the task. Multiple apps are encouraged when each makes a meaningful contribution to the professional workflow or final deliverable.

Counts as a Genuine Task App	Does Not Count
Supports meaningful research, analysis, creation, editing, or verification	Is only opened, named, or briefly visited
Produces or changes information used elsewhere in the workflow	Is used only for setup, navigation, or project administration
Has a clear purpose in the Task Description (Goal)	Display the opening Task Description (Goal) but is not used again

The intro Task Description (Goal) document app counts only if you also use it for substantive task work.

List the same genuine apps in Task Description, Studio, and TaskRecorder.

Single-App Tasks

A single-app task is acceptable. It must meet the same standard for substantive professional work, meaningful skill and judgment, and a clear deliverable as any other task.

There is no minimum task complexity.

All other requirements still apply, including narration, originality, recording length, and a complete deliverable.

Follow the App Categories

Check App Eligibility and Limited Use before choosing your tools. Banned apps must not be opened, displayed or used in new recordings. Minimal use means less than 20% of the task under the project operating rule; background-only and app-specific supporting-use limits still apply; apps in the alternatives-preferred category remain allowed. The cutoff and in-flight protections are stated in that list.

If your planned workflow requires a banned app:

1. Choose a permitted alternative before recording
2. Revise the Task Description
3. Update the Use Apps in Task Description, Studio, and TaskRecorder.

For new work, banned apps must not appear in the recording. Minimal use means less than 20% of the task under the project operating rule; background-only and app-specific supporting-use limits still apply.

Vary the Desktop Appearance

Before recording, change at least one of these; more is better:

- Screen resolution
- Light or dark mode
- Wallpaper (a built-in one)
- Dock size
- Accent color, sidebar icon size, or an in-app theme

The dock must remain on the **left or right** side of the screen, never at the bottom. The dock must not auto-hide and indicators for open applications should be on.

Mouse cursor size & color must stay default.

Pause and Decide

Q: Which recording meets the standard?

❝ **meets the standard.** Each app contributes meaningfully to a connected professional workflow through research, analysis, and stakeholder communication. ❞

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RECORDING QUALITY EXPECTATIONS

🖥️ Onscreen Presentation

On-Screen Presentation

A quality recording should make the work easy to follow visually. Keep the active content visible and use the cursor to direct the viewer's attention.

Manage Windows Clearly

Keep one clear active window, or arrange only the task-relevant windows you need side by side. Other task apps may remain open, but minimize them when you don't need them for the current step.

Do	‼️Avoid ‼️
Use ordinary **Fill** for one active window	Using Full Screen or full-screen Split View
Arrange relevant windows side by side when both are needed	Stacking, overlapping, or pushing windows open
Keep the menu bar, clock, and dock visible. Rearrange or minimize a window if it becomes substantially covered. Keep active windows large and easy to read.	Leaving unused or fully covered windows open. Obscuring a working window. Record window-management issues as qualitative delivery callouts, not numeric acceptance failures. Using small floating windows surrounded by unused desktop

Pop-ups Exception

- Temporary pop-ups or dialogs within the same app may overlap while you are actively using them.

Window Management Examples and Resources

- One-at-a-time window management example (0:31)
- How to use window tiling on Mac | Apple Support (Youtube, 1:16)
- Move and arrange app windows on Mac

Use the Mouse as a Teaching Pointer

The cursor should guide the viewer's attention and make each action easy to follow. Move naturally, pause before acting, and point to the content you are discussing.

✅ Good Example	❌ Bad Example
The cursor moves naturally, shows what is being discussed, and makes the next action clear.	*The cursor moves too quickly and distracts the viewer from the task.*

When practical:

- Point to text, buttons, icons, or interface areas as you discuss or use them.
- Trace along text or an area when it helps direct attention.
- Pause briefly over a useful control so its tooltip or preview can appear.
- Scan the relevant toolbar or panel naturally when locating a tool.
- Use visible interface controls instead of relying only on keyboard shortcuts.

- Clicks should be deliberate and unrushed; **pause about 1 second after every click**.

Move, Pause, Point, and then Act.

Limit Typing Time

Typing is expected, and the cursor may remain still while you type. But it should not dominate the recording.

Recording Type	Typing Limit
Coding + Content & Writing tasks	Up to 35% of the total recording, inclusive
All other tasks	Up to 25% of the total recording, inclusive
Any task	No continuous typing segment longer than 45s. Mouse inactivity is handled separately as a qualitative delivery callout; the closing epilogue may be still.

Break longer entries into shorter segments. Between typing segments, review what you entered, use the cursor to point out important details, format the content, test the result, or complete another meaningful action.

Pause and Decide

Q: Which recording meets the standard?

❝ **meets the standard.** The total typing time is 25% or less for a non-coding task, and every typing segment stays under 45 seconds. ❞

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RECORDING QUALITY EXPECTATIONS

🤐 PII, Licensed Content, and AI Use

PII, Licensed Content, and AI Use

Keep all private information, project materials, unlicensed content, and prohibited AI activity out of the recording. These rules apply to task apps, input files, filenames, notifications, and anything else that may appear on screen.

Note on browser tabs: Websites you only visit for research or context during the task (e.g., reading documentation, looking up reference data) are not input files. They don't need to be in Deliverables.zip or listed in Final Notes. An input file is a file you prepare before recording and open or use in the task. **As such, they are not subject to rules related to CC0 and copyright restrictions, but they must be free of any PII.**

Protect Personal and Project Information

Do not show information that could identify a real private person, including:

- Personal email addresses or phone numbers
- Home addresses
- Account or identification numbers
- Biometrics
- MAC addresses
- Your personal name or account information
- Other private or non-public personal information

PII is not tolerated and will always lead to task rejection.

Where PII slips in without you noticing. Check these before you record, and again in the last few minutes of your video:

• App profile corners: your name or photo in the top-right account area of PowerPoint, Word, Google Docs, Sheets or Slides, or your browser's profile button.

• Usernames in paths: your name in the Finder sidebar, a window title, a save or export dialog (/Users/yourname/...), or the Terminal prompt.

• Logged-in accounts: a personal email or profile photo in Chrome, Gmail, Google Drive or any web app.

• Autofill and history: your name or email in search suggestions, recent-file lists, or notification previews.

Example: an otherwise strong task was sent back because the writer's name and profile photo were visible in PowerPoint's account area at 22:10. The writer never clicked on it; it was just sitting in the corner of the window.

Project information must also be hidden, including references to:

- Mercor
- Project Odin
- Project Odin Writer Guidelines
- Studio instructions or task-management pages
- Other project-administration materials

Project information on screen is not tolerated and will lead to task rejection, the same as PII.

Use Licensed Content

Images, videos, and other downloaded assets must be CC0 or Public Domain. Confirm that the source terms permit commercial use; royalty-free alone does not establish either requirement.

Do not use content that contains:

- A visible creator watermark
- A copyright symbol or ownership notice
- Unverified or unclear licensing
- Paywalled or otherwise restricted material

AI-generated content is acceptable, however, this has to be done before recording.

Avoid Prohibited AI Use

Do not interact with AI or generate or revise task content during recording. Eligible AI-prepared input files may be shown and used if created before recording, with no AI interface, branding, or watermark visible. Follow the prepared-input disclosure instructions in Studio Final Notes.

Use Case	Status	Rule
Standard Google Search results	**Allowed**	Use search results normally
Opening a static link shown in Google AI Overview, including under **Show more**	**Allowed**	Do not interact with the AI Overview
Selecting **Ask anything** in Google AI Overview	**Not allowed**	This begins an AI interaction
Using AI Mode, Gemini, ChatGPT, Claude, or another conversational assistant	**Not allowed**	Do not prompt, chat, ask follow-up questions, generate, or summarize
Using AI to generate task content during recording	**Not allowed**	Task content must be created manually through the recorded professional workflow
Using an AI-powered feature for substantive task work	**Not allowed**	The feature cannot make meaningful task decisions or create the deliverable
Using ordinary built-in functionality that is not presented as AI	**May be allowed**	It must involve no prompting, conversation, generation, or summarization
Running software that contains an AI or ML component	**Conditionally allowed**	It must be part of normal software validation and cannot act as an assistant that completes the task

When an ordinary built-in feature is permitted, narrate the action and result without describing the feature as AI.

AI-Prepared Input Files

An eligible input file may be created with Gemini **before** the recorded session. The file must still meet all privacy, licensing, and prepared-file requirements.

During the recording:

- Do not show the AI tool, interaction, branding, or watermark
    - A Gemini watermark is allowed, as long as Gemini is not used during the recording itself. No other watermark is allowed.
- Do not discuss how the file was generated
- Do not use AI to revise or generate additional task content during recording

Follow the Prepared Input Files instructions for the required disclosure outside the recording.

Pause and Decide

Q: Which recording meets the standard?

❝ **meets the standard.** Fictional information, verified CC0 content, and Google Search without interacting with generative AI. ❞

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